

CUSTOMER RELATIONSHIP MANAGEMENT



Managing Customer Relations, the FOSS-friendly Way!

In this article, we take a look at SugarCRM, an open source, cloud-based Customer Relationship Management solution.

We know that organisations and enterprises, big or small, can save a lot (in terms of time, effort and resources) by switching to open source software. At the simplest level, FOSS offers the liberty to modify and scale the solution as per your needs. Also, you do not have to be bound by weird licence agreement terms, simply because open source licences are not at all restrictive as compared to their proprietary counterparts.

Additionally, the advantages of open source software can be multiplied many times over if migrated to the cloud. Wondering how? Well, the cloud, in itself, reduces implementation and maintenance costs. You do not have to incur recurring expenditure on hardware. Plus, backed by open source solutions, you know you have the option to customise your cloud solutions as and when needed.

Why a CRM?

Every firm, big or small, needs to manage its relationships with its customers and clients. This is where Customer Relationship Management software comes in handy to maintain customer lists, support cases, profiles of sales representatives, and other related information in an organised manner. And quite obviously, an open source CRM solution will provide the added advantages of reduced costs and enhanced flexibility to suit your organisation's needs.

Introducing SugarCRM

SugarCRM is an open source, cloud-based CRM solution that can easily be customised to fit the needs of any organisation. Basically, it caters to small- to mid-sized organisations, enterprises and companies. You can

run it both on the cloud or on-site.

Worried about its open source credentials? Well, SugarCRM happens to be one of the most active open source communities in the enterprise world, with over 250,000 community members, 25,000 developers and nearly 850 extension projects. To quote SugarCRM's website, "With full access to Sugar's source code, customers can take control of their own destiny. SugarCRM customers have the right to run our products anywhere: in their own data-centres, in our data-centres, or at any of a variety of cloud service providers." Impressive, isn't it?

Now, here's the tough part. If you also consider hosting it on the cloud, SugarCRM is free as in *freedom*, not *free stuff*. A regular subscription will cost you \$360 per year, per